



that it was clear that she was the best player in her category in India," she says. In 2024, Radhika had already shifted base to the National Badminton Academy in Guwahati, and in October, Tanvi joined her there to train under coach Park.

The move paid off. In the months that followed, an unseeded Tanvi reached the quarterfinals of the Junior World Championships, losing a tight three-game match to eventual champion Xu Wenjing of China. She then reached the final of the Odisha Masters World Tour 100, won the Denmark International Challenge, and made the final of the US Open.

Long-term goals

She admits the result in Iowa came as a surprise. According to her, Park's target was simply to get her accustomed to a higher level of competition. "I was travelling by myself to the US Open. I was a little nervous also, but I was also excited to be taking care of myself. But coach Park wanted me to play a

World Tour 300 event so I would have some match practice of playing against high-quality players. I also just wanted to play in a World Tour 300 for the first time. I want to go up step by step. I'd played International Challenges and World Tour 100 events before, but the level of players in a World Tour 300 event is much higher," she says.

Tanvi, who entered the tournament ranked World No. 66, was a serious underdog against World No. 20 Thuy Linh Nguyen in the opening round. "I didn't think I'd win that match, but after I did, I just wanted to see how far I could go," she says.

While she couldn't complete a fairytale ending, Tanvi says her coach wasn't disappointed. "When I spoke to him after the tournament, he was very happy. He never expected I would even go that far," says Tanvi, who reached a career-high ranking of World No. 50 after the US Open.

Following the result, coach Park has high expectations from her for the Junior World Championships in

Rising stars: India's Shruti Mishra, Anmol Kharb, and Tanvi Sharma watch intently as P. V. Sindhu faces Thailand's Supanida Katethong in the women's singles final at the 2024 Badminton Asia Team Championships, held in Shah Alam, Selangor. AFP

Indonesia, scheduled from July 23. "Coach Park told me he was very happy with how I did in the USA, but that our main target is the Junior World Championships. So, we will focus on that," she says.

There are other goals too. The 2028 Olympics are just three years away, and although Tanvi will only be 19 then, she's optimistic about making it to Los Angeles. "It will be hard, but it's my dream to win an Olympic gold," she says. But that's for later. Apart from the Junior Worlds this year, Tanvi's got another task she's hoping to excel in. "Next year, I'll have my Class 12 Board Exams. I'm making time every day to study for them and I'm hoping I can do well there as well," she says.